looked quite a bit like me. I'd often been told about people who supposedly bore a resemblance to me, and I'd never been able to see much similarity. But that day I got a shock: They brought in a man in his middle twenties who caused me to do a double-take. It was amazing how much he and I resembled each other—his eyes and hair, his whole facial structure all resembled mine. Since it had been over a century since my great-grandfather had left Ballyporeen for America, it was an eerie experience.

Coming as the president of the United States to this village where my branch of the Reagan family had been launched, learning that some of my ancestors were buried there in paupers' graves, was a warming and emotional experience. Although I've never been a great one for introspection or dwelling on the past, as I looked down the narrow main street of the little town from which an emigrant named Michael Reagan had set out in pursuit of a dream, I had a flood of thoughts, not only about Michael Reagan, but about his son, my grandfather whom I had never met. I thought of Jack and his Irish stories and the drive he'd always had to get ahead; I thought of my own childhood in Dixon, then leaving that small town for Hollywood and later Washington.

What an incredible country we lived in, where the great-grandson of a poor immigrant from Ballyporeen could become president. I couldn't help but think that maybe Jack would have been proud that day. Never had I wished more that he and Nelle were still alive, so they could have been there with me.

After Ireland and a brief stop in London, we took a helicopter ride over the English Channel to France for ceremonies marking the fortieth anniversary of the D-day invasion of Normandy. The first stop was Pointe du Hoc, where American Rangers, 225 of them, had overcome enormous German resistance and climbed a sheer hundred-foot cliff to